



LOSING CONTROL (Left) Protesters line a Colombo street; (top) former Sri Lanka PM Mahinda Rajapaksa with President Gotabaya Rajapaksa

ISHARA S. KODIKARA/AFP

THE FIRST SALVO AGAINST PM MAHINDA CAME FROM HIS OWN PARTY, WITH A GROUP OF MPS ASKING HIM TO RESIGN

apaksas—elder brother, Chamal, was made agriculture minister and younger brother Basil the finance minister. They even installed Mahinda's son, Namal, seen as the heir apparent, as minister of youth and sports.

For Sri Lanka's formidable first family, however, things began to go downhill rapidly. Anti-Rajapaksa protests over high inflation and incompetent governance began with candlelit vigils in the suburbs of the political and commercial capital, Colombo. It soon spread across the country, taking the form of an apolitical, peaceful protest movement calling for the resignation of the president, as well as the rest of the first family. The first one to go was finance minister Basil, who faced flak for his handling of the deteriorating financial situation and his prolonged absence from parliament when Lanka was burning. Chamal and Namal followed soon, in a bid to stem the growing criticism against the Rajapaksas.

However, the protesters were not placated—chanting the catchy 'Gota-go-home' slogan, they demanded president Gotabaya's resignation. They occupied the area in front of the Presidential Secretariat in Colombo overlooking the Galle Face Green esplanade. As the protests grew across the country, party members of the ruling SLPP showed their concern. The first salvo against PM Mahinda came from his own party, with a group of dissident MPs calling for his resignation. They now number over 50 in the country's 225-member parliament, which means Gotabaya Rajapaksa has effectively lost control of support in the legislature. That forced the resignation of Mahinda as prime minister on May 9.

For Mahinda, it was a precipitous fall. As president of the country from 2005 to 2015, he gave political leadership to the armed forces and ensured that they defeated the Tamil Tigers and killed its feared leader, V. Prabhakaran, in 2009. In doing so, he had endeared himself to the majority Sinhala population who make up around 75 per cent of the country's 22 million population. The Sinhalese, who are mainly Buddhists, referred to him fondly as 'appachchi', Sinhala for 'father'. But by last week, he was a hunted man, having to quit his job as angry crowds besieged his official residence in Colombo soon after his resignation. Army personnel had to step in to airlift him to safety the next day; he is said to be at a naval base in Eastern Sri Lanka.

Mahinda was also blamed for the escalating violence when he is said to have brought a host of party workers to his Colombo residence to shore up support for him the day he sent his resignation to the president. These workers set upon the peaceful protesters, escalating the situation and triggering sudden violence across the country, in which those linked to the Rajapaksas have been targeted. To control the situation, Gotabaya has imposed emergency rule, giving additional powers to the armed forces, and put a curfew in place. But this has not stopped angry crowds from